

not an option. This does not mean we must not or cannot fail. It only means we must be able to get back up on our feet each time we hit a roadblock. A comfortable corpus obtained by investing your salary, provides a cushion to bounce back. While we follow our dreams, we must assure our day to day expenses are taken care, irrespective of how the startup is faring.

When you start your venture - it could be organic food production, a cake shop, a marketing firm etc., it is not realistic to expect these endeavors to support your daily expenses right from the start. Some may take 3 years, some 5 or even 10 to pay your bills.

When your annual expenses are about 2.5 Lakhs (*just for the essentials*) and you estimate 3 years to see profit from the onset, then you would need about $2.5 \times 3 = 7.5$ lakhs (annual expenses x no of years payout is needed).^[35] In essence you should have this amount as you start the venture. Bootstrapping and other ideas are gilded pathways but having enough cover is prudent. The inflation in your expenses matches the return obtained (after taxes) from the corpus and so, if you can save a corpus close to this number, you can work on your idea without worrying about bills for the next few years.

The question now is: How long it would take to accumulate 7-8 lakhs? This will depend on how badly you want to get working on the idea. If you wish to begin work right away, you could start by beginning to clock in after-hours while still being employed at a different firm. If you'd like to solely focus and go full throttle on the idea, you will have to postpone some desires - a holiday or two, or that bike - and invest as much as possible from your salary. It boils down to priorities.

Happy hustling!

Case 2: I don't want to work again!

“Mint money and retire at 40. That’s the plan”

- Hrithik Roshan, *Arjun*, Zindagi na Milegi Dobara

Let's say you want to stop working for a salary altogether by age 40 and travel the world or join an NGO and teach underprivileged children - this would mean drastically different plans to our spending patterns.